and murder] set off a chain of events in which Israel gradually lost control of the situation, finally ending up on the brink of a war that nobody wanted."[25]

The first week and a half was a confusing blur. Hamas launched an average of 143 rockets per day, but they were almost entirely ineffective; only one Israeli was killed, an ultra-Orthodox man who had volunteered to distribute food to soldiers on the border. Israel carried out more than 200 daily airstrikes, which killed 241 Palestinians, a figure that would soon seem modest. The army-backed government in Cairo, which has a warm security relationship with Israel and an abiding hatred for Hamas—it rightly accuses the group of working with militants on the Sinai Peninsula—tried to broker a ceasefire with the quiet assistance of former British Prime Minister Tony Blair. It was hard to tell whether the war would be a rerun of 2012, a relatively restrained eight-day battle, or 2008–9, a fierce ground campaign.

From the Israeli side, in those early days, it was still largely a conflict happening "over there", a bombing campaign beyond the wall that occasionally intruded on daily life. On 12 July, Hamas announced that it would fire a new kind of rocket at Tel Aviv at exactly 9 pm, a PR stunt timed for maximum exposure on the evening news. A few minutes before the barrage, I sat on my balcony overlooking Jaffa's trendy flea market and watched a group of young Israelis—drinks in hand—totter into my parking garage, which was doubling as a bomb shelter. The sirens went off (a few minutes late, because it was the Middle East); the rockets were intercepted by the Iron Dome defense system, or missed their marks; and the partygoers wandered back to the bar to top off their drinks.

In an ironic twist, the Hamas-run TV channel took a live feed from Channel 2, Israel's largest broadcaster, hoping to show its viewers images of panic and destruction in Tel Aviv. The hoped-for images never came, so Hamas accused the network of using recorded video. When Al Jazeera, the Qatari-funded pan-Arabic broadcaster, described Tel Aviv as a "ghost town", the Israeli army's Arabic spokesman quipped back, "I'm sure life in Tel Aviv is more vibrant than Doha at the moment."

There was one scene of panic that evening, but it wasn't caused by rockets. A few kilometers from Jaffa, next to the national theater on Tel Aviv's central HaBima Square, a few hundred Israelis were holding an anti-war demonstration. They faced off with a smaller group of counter-